

Investigating the Language and Sentiments in Discussions of Homelessness Across News Publications

INTRODUCTION

Our goal was to discover how media coverage of homelessness varies in terms of focus and portrayals of criminality across different publications. Homelessness is a multifaceted social issue that not only challenges the affected individuals and communities but also reflects broader societal attitudes and policies. The media plays a crucial role in shaping public perceptions and discourse surrounding homelessness. It influences policy agendas and public responses. Media coverage can significantly impact public perception, policy formulation, and resource allocation concerning homelessness. Media coverage has the power to influence policymakers and the public agenda, helping hold both policymakers and institutions accountable for their responses to homelessness.

Negative or stereotypical portrayals may perpetuate stigma and discrimination against homeless individuals, creating social bias that inhibits reintegration into the community as well as access to support. Conversely, balanced and accurate reporting could raise awareness of the structural issues that contribute to homelessness and encourage policies to address its root causes, such as affordable housing and social services. However, the portrayal of homelessness in the media is often influenced by factors such as political ideology, socio-economic context, and journalistic priorities.

Our study examines how homelessness is discussed in the media by analyzing news coverage across the political spectrum. We ask: How does media coverage of homelessness vary in terms of focus and portrayals of criminality across different news publications?

METHODOLOGY

To gain insights into how different media outlets frame and narrate the issue of homelessness, we created variables we call the crime proportion and the affected-to-homeless ratio. We collected articles from 12 publications across the political spectrum. Using ground .news, we labeled publications as far-left, left-center, center, right-center, and far-right. Each label was then assigned a corresponding numeric value between 1 (far left) and 5 (far right). Using mediabiasfactcheck.com, we assigned a numeric value to their reported factuality. This ranged from very low(1), low(2), mixed(3), mostly factual(4), high(6) and very high(7). This value served as the credibility score for each publication. All publications were accounted for on both websites.

On each platform, we searched the keyword “homelessness” and filtered our results by date. We selected the six most recent articles that specifically focused on homelessness within the United States. We hand-annotated each article to calculate the crime proportion and the affected: homeless focus ratio.

When collecting data for the crime proportion, mentions of crime were compared to the total number of sentences. We did not discern whether crime mentions were by homeless individuals or against homeless individuals. For our affected: homeless ratio, we marked sentences based on their narrative focus. Those that focused on the impact of homelessness on buildings and individuals living in proximity to homeless communities (e.g., property damage, safety concerns, and community tensions) were tallied as “affected”. Conversely, sentences with a focus on the lived experience of

homelessness itself (e.g., exploring the challenges faced by individuals without stable housing, including issues of poverty, mental health, and social exclusion) were tallied as “homeless.”

Other variables of interest were whether the publication had a paywall, whether it was available in print, and whether it was national or otherwise. Each was assigned a value of True or False. Beyond the scope of this study, we may be interested in analyzing paywall prices, article-specific political biases, and city- or state-specific reports as additional predictors.

CONCLUSION

Our analysis generally confirmed our predictions. Bias emerged as the most influential predictor; surprisingly, the presence of a paywall was also a strong predictor. We had anticipated that credibility would play a significant role, but we found that bias had a more pronounced effect on the topics covered.

The correlation between bias and criminality was statistically significant (p-value = 0.00548), meaning that you can reliably use bias to predict how often crime is mentioned in these articles. Our bias scale ranged from “extreme left” (1) to “extreme right” (7). The higher an article was rated, the further right it was, and the more it mentioned crime. We found that, on average, right-wing articles mention crime about three times as often as left-wing articles (11.3% vs. 3.7% of sentences).

Surprisingly, the coverage ratio between those affected by homelessness and the homeless themselves was influenced not only by bias (p-value = 0.0522) but also by the presence of a paywall (p-value = 0.0335). This finding became clear after analyzing model one and removing “print” as a variable. We discovered that all printed publications were also paywalled, suggesting a close relationship between the two. Removing the print made the paywall's influence more significant. This correlation allows us to predict that a free, left-wing publication will focus more on homeless people than on those affected.

Our findings suggest that bias significantly impacts the content of publications. Right-wing publications tend to focus more on criminal behavior, particularly when

discussing homelessness. This correlation suggests that knowing a publication's political leaning can predict its coverage of certain topics. For instance, right-leaning outlets are more likely to discuss crime in relation to homelessness compared to left-leaning ones.

We were surprised and intrigued by the influence of a paywall on the affected: homeless ratio. We speculated that paywalled newspapers might focus more on the affected population than on the homeless themselves because they cater to wealthier demographics and prioritize stories that resonate with their readers.

In summary, bias was a strong predictor of both variables, supporting our hypotheses, whereas credibility had a smaller impact because it focused on factual accuracy rather than political perspective. The presence of a paywall was a surprising and exciting find, opening avenues for follow-up research into the connection between bias and monetary barriers. Overall, our research sheds light on how media bias shapes narratives around societal issues such as homelessness and crime. As our country simmers in hyperpartisanship, understanding how our institutions contribute to division is essential.

RESPONSES TO QUESTIONS

Distinction between crime done *by* vs *against* homeless people?

When collecting data for this project, we didn't typically see a distinction between crimes committed *by* or *against* homeless people. Most of the time, we counted a sentence toward our crime proportion if it was related to criminality in general, such as mentions of crime, drugs, etc.

Why use Media Bias Fact Check? Does it cover all sources?

We decided to use Media Bias Fact Check as our singular source for marking each publication's bias (political leaning) and credibility. The reason we used this website, rather than a combination of different sources, is that Media Bias Fact Check had the most comprehensive list of publications. This meant we could cover local publications alongside national publications in our data collection. In the future, it would be better to use an aggregate of multiple fact-checkers, but since Media Bias Fact Check is a well-regarded source, we found no issues with using it as our sole metric for bias.

Why use the most recent articles?

COVID-19 significantly reshaped the landscape of homelessness. We felt that choosing articles from a broad time span would not only be inconsistent but also make our findings inapplicable to the modern situation, which is facing many developments (Oregon Supreme Court case, etc.). It would be interesting to include time as another

factor in a separate study, but for the sake of simplicity, we chose to focus only on recent articles.

Geographic origin of the article?

Originally, we had planned to look only at one city, such as New York or Portland. As we researched, we realized that the body of articles focusing on just one city wouldn't be enough to draw strong conclusions, and opted to look at the nation as a whole instead. To compensate, we added a Boolean predictor "local/national." If we had the time and resources to compare by city, it would have been interesting to see how publications treat the issue differently across the country; however, the limitations of this project prevented us from exploring all the variables we wanted to.

Why was the Print variable dropped in Model 2?

When looking at the correlation matrix for our first Model, we can see that the Print predictor has a high correlation (above 0.5) for all predictors except nationality (-0.17) and credibility (-5.4e-18). This makes it the single predictor with the highest correlation among the predictors, justifying its removal in our second model.

What counts as "crime"?

In an ideal world, we would've had a stronger methodology for counting references to "crime" and affect/homeless mentions. Our methodology counted any sentence that explicitly mentioned either the word "crime" or any specific crime that was committed. Since this was broad, we didn't define a list of terms beforehand; instead, we worked

together as we went along and worked out trickier cases as a group. In the future, it would be ideal to have a list of phrases that could then be automatically counted in a program like R.